Navigating the Gaps: Patient Agency and Systemic Barriers in Healthcare

An analysis of patient experiences highlighting systemic challenges and opportunities for empowerment.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

- Patients are often forced to become their own experts to navigate knowledge gaps and fragmentation within the healthcare system.
- Peer communities provide an essential lifeline of validation, connection, and information where formal systems fall short.
- A new diagnosis can trigger overwhelming confusion and anxiety, hindering a patient's ability to actively engage in their own care.
- After active treatment ends, survivors frequently face a lack of coordinated care and support for ongoing physical and emotional challenges.

KEY INSIGHTS

Patients are compelled to engage in extensive self-education and persistent self-advocacy to compensate for knowledge gaps and navigational difficulties within the healthcare system.

> *"A patient expresses frustration over the lack of information provided by the healthcare system, forcing them to do their own research."*
>
> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0040.DOCX

> *"A clinician acknowledges the training gaps that prevent doctors from providing comprehensive information to patients."*
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> — CLINICIAN • EP. UTH_WH_0051.DOCX

In the face of social isolation and a lack of institutional support, individuals actively create and seek out peer communities to find validation, share stories, and access crucial information, which serves as a vital protective factor.

> *"A patient describes the profound relief and connection felt upon finding a support group and realizing she was not alone."*
>
> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0045

The complexity of navigating a fragmented healthcare system immediately following a diagnosis, coupled with a lack of clear information, induces significant emotional overwhelm, confusion, and anxiety, often leading to a state of passive endurance rather than active engagement in care.

> *"A patient describes the feeling of being completely overwhelmed by the number of appointments and decisions after a cancer diagnosis."*
>
> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0045.DOCX

Patients who cultivate deep body awareness and proactively track symptoms are better equipped to identify changes that may be missed by routine screenings, enabling the self-advocacy required to overcome potential diagnostic delays.

> *"A patient recounts how her regular self-checks allowed her to notice a subtle change that her recent mammogram had missed."*
>
> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0040.DOCX

After active treatment ends, survivors often enter a phase of care characterized by fragmented support, a lack of information about long-term effects, and a lack of validation for their ongoing physical and emotional challenges, leaving them to navigate an uncertain future alone.

> *"A patient describes the shock of being 'cut loose' after treatment, with no plan for managing long-term side effects."*
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> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0047.DOCX

Individuals struggle to articulate their experiences and needs when they lack a shared, non-stigmatizing language, which creates significant barriers to receiving validation and support, even within peer communities.

> *"A patient expresses relief at learning a clinical term for her experience, as it gave her a way to talk about it and feel validated."*
>
> — PATIENT • EP. UTH_WH_0063.DOCX

METHODOLOGY

6	23	High confidence insights were prioritized for this report.
EPISODES	MOMENTS	CONFIDENCE